



promising talents for their teams. "Back then, it was a trial and error method as there were no formula for it," Desai, who worked for seven seasons at Rajasthan Royals, says.

Scouts used to earn between Rs 6 lakh to Rs 10 lakh annually. Now, the salaries have significantly risen and vary based on the scouts' profiles.

"With the IPL, a lot of former cricketers and people who are passionate about the game have been able to be associated with it in various sectors and that's the best part about it," Desai says.

"Even some of the lesser known players are also part of scouting now because they have the eye, and are curious about tracking a player - not just his game but also his background. So, everything put together, the concept of scouting is fast evolving and there are more and more opportunities..."

More than a decade ago, Mumbai Indians roped in former New Zealand captain and erstwhile India coach John Wright as the chief of scouting. India international Rahul Sanghvi joined alongside him. Taking a cue from Mumbai Indians, Delhi Capitals hired Pravin Amre, Saba Karim, whereas Punjab Kings has availed the services of Reetinder Singh Sodhi and VRRV Singh over the years.

Franchises typically maintain a team of five to six scouts, each assigned to specific zones. They

primarily focus on BCCI-approved age-group tournaments, state-level U-19 and U-23 tournaments, and the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy held just before the IPL auction.

A scout, on condition of anonymity, reveals that the job involves discovering new talents, closely monitoring them for at least three to four local tournaments, and providing insights into their strengths and weaknesses to the franchise's analysts and coaches. The final decision on whether a player fits into the team's plans rests with the coaching staff.

In contrast to the past preference for notable overseas coaches, Indian coaches are now securing prominent roles. For instance, Kolkata Knight Riders appointed Chandrakant Pandit as its head coach last season, recognising his success with teams like Madhya Pradesh and Vidarbha in domestic tournaments. While domestic coaches like Bharucha, Vijay Dahiya, Ajay Ratra, Sunil Joshi, Joydeep Mukherjee, Dishant Yagnik, and Trevor Gonsalves have long been part of the system as assistant coaches, Pandit marked a significant shift as the first high-profile domestic coach in the head coach role.

"The best part about the IPL is the fact that there are so many opportunities and it's not restricted to just cricketing affairs. Now, there are several cricketers who are hired by

Big leap: Chandrakant Pandit, a highly regarded coach on the Indian domestic circuit, is KKR's first Indian head coach. SPORTZPICS / IPL

teams for specific specialist roles and that also creates newer opportunities and employment," Pandit says.

"I know one of the spinners who is called by different franchises to help out spinners. Similarly, former fast bowlers are invited to specially conduct 15-day camps to help out the fast bowlers in respective franchises," Pandit says. "I won't call it a job, but it's certainly an opportunity for former cricketers to be part of the game. Now, no former player can complain of not getting anything after retirement because there are various ways to be connected to the game through the IPL."

Pandit highlights the transformation from the past when cricketers were uncertain about their post-retirement prospects. **The IPL now serves as a platform for players to showcase their skills and secure employment, extending beyond roles in scouting or coaching.** In the inaugural edition, Shishir Hattangadi, the former Mumbai captain, served as the CEO of the now-defunct Deccan Chargers. Presently, broadcasting has taken centre stage, with numerous former players joining this sector.

According to industry insiders, the pay structure for domestic coaches varies based on their profile and experience. A renowned domestic coach could earn up to Rs 2 crore per season, while assistant coaches typically receive between Rs 25 to 50 lakh (approximately). However, players with a substantial tenure representing India naturally have greater bargaining power.

A similar trend is observed in the broadcast sector. In earlier times, only a handful of top retired Indian cricketers engaged in broadcast and commentary for the IPL. As the league expanded, the broadcast coverage expanded to several regional languages, in addition to English and Hindi.

Previously, Star Sports, the global rights holder, offered IPL